

can take multitouch for granted will be able to craft application interfaces that take advantage of that; just as GUIs went through many changes in style, presentation and functionality since their early days. The real question then becomes, does multitouch improve productivity on desktops enough for it to take off? It probably will for laptops with



Desktops with touch screens will probably require some adaptations before they can be used efficiently

smaller screens, but on desktops will the cost of a large multitouch screen be too prohibitive? Only time will tell.

With that said, let us get back to our point about the support for touch in Windows. Windows 7 supported multitouch, but did not have a GUI that could really be used with touch alone. Windows 8 on the other hand finally includes a way of using Windows that is touch centric.

Principally the new design philosophy of Windows 8 is quite sound, and doesn't even have to do with just touch. Most current GUIs are based on the principle of skeuomorphism; which means that they try to equate the design of digital items from real world items. For example a folder icon in Windows Explorer actually looks like a real-world folder, a button is often visibly bevelled and so on. It essentially covers any bit of design that is entirely ornamental and meant to evoke the feeling of using a physical object rather than a digital one.

You might have seen applications that have odd UIs such as an actual knob to change volume, or actual pages with shadows in an eBook reading application, or a notebook application that is ruled. The problem with these is that while they evoke familiarity, they can also potentially confuse. For example, you can't really turn a knob displayed on screen as you would a normal knob, neither can you turn pages like a real book in an eBook reader. Other references can become quickly obsolete, children of the current generation have probably never used a physical address book, yet you will find applications designed – visually – like a leather bound address book.

Microsoft wants to eschew such practises in their new design, and as such we have Modern UI, which in their terms is “authentically digital”. The aim is to have a clear and clean design where buttons can be simple